The tour began with a warm-up match against Somerset in Taunton, and our planning was rocked by the freakish eye injury, described in an earlier chapter, that forced a premature end to Mark Boucher's distinguished career. Gary Kirsten and Graeme asked me to take over as wicketkeeper, and we carried on.

Properly prepared and motivated, we also played some outstanding cricket.

We won the first Test at The Oval by an innings and 12 runs. After starting slowly on the first day, we increased our intensity on the second day, reducing England from 271 for three to 385 all out. We then batted and batted to reach 637 for two declared, with Graeme making 131, Jacques scoring an unbeaten 182 and Hashim making an epic 311 not out. The home side was deflated, dismissed for 240 and defeated.

To have so comprehensively won a Test match against an England team standing at No. 1 in the Test rankings, and to have lost only two wickets in the process, was an amazing achievement.

Headingley in Leeds is one of my favourite grounds, partly because I have always seemed to score runs there and partly because of the atmosphere generated on the Western Terrace but, in the second Test of 2012, Kevin Pietersen's brilliant century put us on the back foot and we were content to settle for a draw.

The third and final Test was played at Lord's, an exceptional sporting arena rightly known as the home of cricket and renowned for its outstanding atmosphere and stands, ranging from the famous Victorian red-brick pavilion to the remarkable giant space ship of a Media Centre perched at the Nursery End.

In my view, Lord's stands apart because, from the moment they arrive at the ground, players are made to feel so important and valued. Everyone is helpful and attentive – and the lunches always used to be the finest in world cricket, with four main meals and prawns on offer, followed by an amazing array of puddings.